

Prompt Engineering for Non-Developers

Get Better Responses from Generative AI

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Introduction

If you are a technical writer, analyst, or other professional using or testing generative AI tools, you have likely encountered inaccurate data, generic content, bias, or inconsistent responses.

The good news is that you can greatly improve generative AI responses through **prompt engineering** or the practice of crafting clear, specific prompts that generate responses that make your work more efficient and useful. And you can do it without having to learn programming or have machine learning expertise.

This guide introduces you to practical, code-free prompt engineering techniques and frameworks you can use immediately to get the high-quality generative AI responses you want.

Why Prompts Matter

Whenever you interact with an AI model by asking it a question or giving it instructions, you are using a **prompt** to generate its response. The clarity and specificity of your prompt directly affect the quality of the model's response.

Generic Prompts Lead to Generic Responses

Generative AI is advanced technology, but not so advanced that AI models can read your mind. AI models respond to what you say, not what you mean. Which of the following prompts do you think will generate the best response?

Prompt A

“Summarize this report.”

Prompt B

“Summarize this report in 4 bullet points at an 8th-grade reading level.”

Prompt B generates a better response that follows your more specific instructions.

Lack of Context Leads to Lack of Understanding

Just as with humans, the quickest way to generate an inaccurate response from an AI model is to leave out the context of your request.

For example, if you instruct the model to “Write an email” you have a much lower chance of receiving an effective result than instructing the model to “Assume you are a consulting firm account manager and haven't heard from your biggest client in a few weeks. Draft a friendly email to check in.”

Prompt Iteration Improves Response Quality

Iteration is a key part of improving generative AI responses. The first response generated by an AI model is not always the best one possible. Revising your prompt allows you to clarify instructions, add context, and improve the response.

For example, the following prompt iterations would gradually produce a better response.

Prompt 1

Write a short blurb about the benefits of drinking smoothies.

First Prompt Iteration

Write a 60-character blurb that includes at least 3 benefits of drinking smoothies.

Second Prompt Iteration

Find a quote that is 60 characters or less from a nutrition expert that includes at least 3 benefits of drinking smoothies.

Write a Better Prompt

The following steps provide a repeatable framework for writing effective prompts. You can remember it using the mnemonic phrase “GRASP IT.”

Step 1 – **G**oal

Define the response you want the AI model to produce.

“I want to write content for a web page that clearly explains our product’s automated data synchronization feature and its benefits to a non-technical business user.”

Step 2 – **R**ole

Assign the AI model a role that guides its tone and expertise.

“You are an experienced technical writer who specializes in explaining complex software features to non-technical business users and has a deep knowledge of our product.”

Step 3 – **A**dd Constraints

Adding constraints will improve the clarity of the response. Possible constraints might include audience, tone, length, format, education level, and quantity of responses.

“Explain the feature in plain language for a non-technical business audience using 3-4 short paragraphs.”

Step 4 – **S**pecify the Task

Give the AI model clear, specific instructions.

“Write a short section that is less than 180 characters that explains the benefits of the feature to users and includes an example scenario.”

Step 5 – **P**rovide context

Include context and/or examples in your prompt to generate relevant responses.

“This web page will be visited by internal employees who are intermediate-level users of the software but may not understand how background data updates work.”

Step 6 – **I**terate and ask for revision

Provide your AI model with follow-up instructions or revisions numerous times until you receive the response you require.

“Rewrite the explanation without any technical jargon and tailor it for a user with a high-school level of education.”

After following the steps described above, your final prompt might fit together as follows.

“Role: Technical writer explaining software to non-technical business users.

Task: Explain the automated data synchronization feature.

Constraints: 3–4 short paragraphs, plain language, no jargon. Include a <180-character example showing the benefit.

Context: Internal web page for employees who use the software but may not understand background data updates.”

Organizing prompts into clear components such as role, task, constraints, and context can make them easier to write, review, and revise.

Prompt Examples

For further understanding of how you can use prompt engineering to greatly improve your generative AI responses, consider the following examples.

Example 1 – Summarize a document

Original Prompt

“Summarize this product requirements document.”

Prompt Issues

This prompt does not provide enough direction for the AI model and will likely result in a summary that is too long, too technical, and/or focused on the wrong information.

Specifically, the issues with this prompt are:

- **Vague instructions.** The prompt does not specify the type of summary needed or the level of detail it should contain.
- **Missing context.** The AI model does not know the summary’s purpose or how it will be used.
- **Unclear audience.** The prompt does not identify the summary’s target audience.

Revised Prompt

“You are a technical writer summarizing this product requirements document for a non-technical project manager. Provide five concise bullet points that highlight the main feature requirements, key deadlines, and risks.”

Why the Response will Improve

The revised prompt will improve the response because it provides clear instructions that define the model’s role, target audience, and the desired format and scope.

Example 2 – Draft a Client Email

Original Prompt

“Write an email to a client about a product update.”

Prompt Issues

This prompt is too generic for the AI model to produce an effective email and may result in a response that is missing important details.

The specific issues with this prompt are:

- **Generic instructions.** The prompt does not explain what the product update is or what the client needs to know.
- **Missing context.** The model does not know the relationship with the client or the purpose of the communication.
- **Unclear tone and format.** The prompt does not specify whether the email should be formal, brief, or persuasive.

Revised Prompt

“You are a customer success manager writing to a client about a new reporting feature in our analytics platform. Draft a short email explaining the feature, highlight how it benefits the client, and invite them to schedule a demonstration.”

Why the Response will Improve

The revised prompt will improve the response because it clearly defines the context of the message and the purpose of the communication. By identifying the model’s role and the key information the email should contain, the prompt guides the AI toward producing a more relevant and useful response.

Example 3 – Explain a Complex Product Feature

Original Prompt

“Explain how role-based content access works.”

Issue

This prompt is likely to produce a response that is overly technical or difficult for non-technical readers to understand.

Specifically, the issues with this prompt are:

- **Unclear audience.** The prompt does not specify whether the explanation is intended for engineers, customers, or business stakeholders.
- **Missing context.** The model does not know what type of software platform the feature belongs to.
- **Lack of constraints.** The prompt does not specify the desired length, format, or level of technical detail.

Revised Prompt

“You are a technical writer explaining our project management software to new customers. Write a short explanation of role-based content access in plain language and include a brief example showing how different team members (such as managers and content authors) may have different permissions.”

Why the Response will Improve

The revised prompt will improve the response because it clearly defines the model's role, identifies the target audience, and provides context about the software platform. It also requests a practical example, which helps make a complex concept easier for non-technical users to understand.

Common Prompting Mistakes

The following table highlights common prompting mistakes and shows how the steps described in this guide help address them.

Prompting Mistake	Related Step	How to Fix It
Vague prompts	Step 1 – Define the Goal; Step 4 – Specify the Task	Clearly describe the response you want. Example: “Summarize this report in five bullet points highlighting key findings.”
Requesting too many tasks at once	Step 4 – Specify the Task	Break complex requests into smaller prompts and complete them in stages rather than asking the AI model to do everything at once.
Not specifying the audience	Step 3 – Add Constraints	Identify who the response is for and the appropriate tone or level of detail. Example: “Explain this feature for non-technical business users.”
Missing context	Step 5 – Provide Context	Include background information about the product, situation, or goal so the AI model can generate a more relevant response.
Assuming the response is correct	Step 6 – Iterate and Revise	Review the response critically and ask the AI model to clarify, shorten, or revise the answer if necessary.

Quick Reference

GRASP IT

Goal

Define the response you want to generate.

Role

Assign a role that guides its tone and expertise.

Add Constraints

Add constraints such as audience, content length, format, reader education level, and response quantity.

Specify the Task

Give clear, specific instructions.

Provide Context

Include context and examples.

Iteration

Revise your prompt until the response you require is generated.

Prompt Writing Checklist

- ☐ Did I clearly define the goal of the response?
- ☐ Did I assign a role or perspective to the AI?
- ☐ Did I specify the audience?
- ☐ Did I include constraints (tone, format, length)?
- ☐ Did I provide useful context?
- ☐ Did I review the response critically?

Common Prompt Revisions

- Make it shorter
- Adjust the audience
- Improve clarity
- Provide alternatives
- Add structure